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Career transitions from work-to-entrepreneurship

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ABSTRACT

Moving from a traditional career to entrepreneurship is a significant shift. It means taking on new responsibilities and dealing with uncertainties. Our research examined what motivates people and the skills they need to make this change. We used career identity theory to understand how people match their motivations, interests, and abilities with their chosen careers. By thematically analyzing 21 in-depth interviews conducted with military veterans and career transition organizations, we find that transition barriers and challenges embedded in career contexts can be overcome by leveraging career capital and social capital through a series of adjustments. The value of career transitions to entrepreneurship was linked to improved well-being, increased autonomy, and satisfaction. We contribute to the entrepreneurship and career literature by proposing an integrative model of work-to-entrepreneurship career pathways, which aids in explaining how occupation contexts shape career aspirations, highlighting the importance of career and social capital and identifying career transition pathways. We propose direction for future research and offer practical implications for employers' talent management practitioners, individuals considering work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions and interorganizational talent management practices in entrepreneurship ecosystems.

RÉSUMÉ

Passer d'une carrière traditionnelle à l'entrepreneuriat est un changement significatif. Il s'agit d'assumer de nouvelles responsabilités et de faire face à des incertitudes. Notre recherche s'est penchée sur les motivations des individus et sur les compétences dont ils ont besoin pour effectuer ce changement. Nous avons employé la théorie de l'identité professionnelle pour comprendre comment les gens font correspondre leurs motivations, leurs intérêts et leurs capacités avec la carrière choisie par eux. À l'aide de l'analyse thématique de 21 entretiens en profondeur conduits avec des vétérans de l'armée et des organismes de transition de carrière, nous montrons que les obstacles à la transition et les défis inhérents aux contextes de carrière peuvent être

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surmontés en tirant parti du capital professionnel et du capital social à travers une série d'ajustements. La valeur des transitions de carrière vers l'entrepreneuriat s'est révélée liée à l'amélioration du bien-être, l'accroissement de l'autonomie et la satisfaction. Nous contribuons à la littérature sur l'entrepreneuriat et les carrières en proposant un modèle intégratif des parcours professionnels de l'emploi à l'entrepreneuriat, qui aide à expliquer comment les contextes professionnels déterminent les aspirations professionnelles, en soulignant l'importance de la carrière et du capital social et en identifiant les parcours de transition de carrière. Nous proposons une orientation pour les recherches futures et offrons des implications pratiques pour les praticiens de la gestion des talents, les personnes qui envisagent des transitions de carrière entre l'emploi et l'entrepreneuriat, et les pratiques de gestion des talents inter-organisationnels dans les écosystèmes de l'entrepreneuriat.

1. Introduction

The transition from work-to-entrepreneurship is emerging as a significant area of interest among scholars and practitioners. Individuals are expected to change jobs five to seven times throughout their professional lives (Huynh 2022). This trend is particularly pronounced among millennials, who are projected to comprise nearly 40% of the global workforce by 2030 (Brown et al. 2020a). Unlike previous generations, millennials prefer dynamic and individualized career paths, embracing more frequent career changes (Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). As career patterns become more complex (De Vos, Jacobs, and Verbruggen 2021), there is a growing interest in entrepreneurial careers, driven by technological advancements, demand for flexible work, and the rising acceptance of entrepreneurship as a career (Idowu and Elbanna 2022; GEM (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor) 2023/2024).

Given these trends, scholars increasingly focus on individuals pursuing entrepreneurial careers, examining their qualities, strategies, incentives, and perceived benefits (Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev 2016; de Villiers Scheepers et al. 2018). As traditional career paths become more fluid, understanding work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions is crucial for both entrepreneurship and career scholars.

Several studies have examined work-to-work transitions from employment to self-employment (Zou et al. 2023; Stephanus and Vero 2024). While the entrepreneurship literature has been criticized for overrepresenting homogeneous samples (Welter et al. 2017), there is a growing body of research focusing on the career transitions of women entrepreneurs (Lewis et al. 2015; Norman, Aiken, and Greer 2024), senior entrepreneurs (Ainsworth 2014; Kautonen et al. 2023) and sport entrepreneurs (Boyd, Keith Harrison, and McNerny 2021; Winand, Bell, and Zeimers 2023). Yet, few studies examine mid-career transitions, focusing on the interplay of occupational environment and agency, career capital and the transition pathways of previously employed individuals.

This study aims to address these gaps by gaining a nuanced understanding of work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions. Adopting a social constructivist

approach, we explore the occupational context and agency of individuals reimagining and pursuing entrepreneurial careers. We focus on the following research questions: (1) how do contextual barriers and facilitators influence work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions? (2) how do career and social capital shape career transition experiences? and (3) how do individuals perceive the value of pursuing an entrepreneurial career?

To explore these questions, we study the career transitions of military veterans, an understudied group of theoretical and practical importance. Military veterans' transitions to entrepreneurship represent an extreme case of work-to-self-employment transitions, given their embeddedness in their occupational environment. Extreme cases are helpful for theory elaboration and discovery (Seawright 2016). Veterans' perceptions of barriers and facilitators are influenced by occupational cultural embeddedness and socialization, making their career imagination foundational to their experiences. Their career and social capital are strongly tied to their service, and transitioning to civilian life or self-employment requires significant adjustment.

Practically, veterans represent untapped entrepreneurial capital with unique skills and experiences valuable to entrepreneurship ecosystems. Studies highlight their potential contributions to economies in the United States, United Kingdom, Australia, New Zealand, South Korea, and Scandinavian countries (Edelmann 2018; Becker et al. 2022; Ahlbäck, Sundevall, and Hjertquist 2024). Veterans are prepared to lead, adapt, and make decisions under uncertainty (Haynie and Shepherd 2011; Heinz et al. 2017). However, transitioning from structured military careers to the ambiguity of entrepreneurship is challenging (Rose, VanDenKerkhof, and Schaub 2018).

Our research contributes to the work-to-entrepreneurship transition literature in three ways through the proposed integrative model of career pathways. First, the model integrates career imagination and career and social capital, enabling a synthesis of structural and agency perspectives and explaining how occupation contexts shape career aspiration and perceived constraints and enablement informing new possible careers. Second, the model highlights how career and social capital can be leveraged to overcome perceived challenges and turn possibilities into reality through continuous adjustment. Third, the model outlines three transition pathways as a starting point for future research to expand when studying more diverse groups. Practically, we offer managerial implications for employers and talent management, individuals considering work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions and interorganizational talent management in entrepreneurship ecosystems.

2. Literature review and theoretical foundations

Research on career transitions and entrepreneurship pathways needs to be better versed. Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev (2016) emphasize that entrepreneurship should be seen as a step along a career trajectory, not a final destination. Similarly, Akkermans et al. (2024) acknowledge the complexity of modern career paths and call for research into specific career transitions, such as work-to-self-employment. While progress has been made in studying entrepreneurial career intentions and patterns

(Marshall and Gigliotti 2020; Koch, Park, and Zahra 2021), this study seeks deeper insight into work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions.

Table 1 provides an overview of recent literature (2020 to 2024) on work-to-self-employment transitions, focusing on career decisions in a complex and turbulent environment. These studies focus on entrepreneurial intent (St-Jean and Duhamel 2020; Seibert, Nielsen, and Kraimer 2021), self-employment generally (Otchia 2021; Gu et al. 2024), late-career transitions (Gray and Smith 2020; Ramnath, Shoven, and Slavov 2021; Kautonen et al. 2023), women entrepreneurs (Song 2024) and career dismissal (Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022). One study examined the transitions of Chinese academics from the public sector to entrepreneurship (Zou et al. 2023). These studies use diverse methodologies, including secondary datasets and longitudinal panel data (St-Jean and Duhamel 2020; Otchia 2021; Ramnath et al. 2021; Kautonen et al. 2023) from emerging and developed economies, and interviews for deeper insight into participants' lived experiences (Gray and Smith 2020; Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022; Zou et al. 2023; Song 2024). Theories used include entrepreneurial event models, the theory of planned behaviour (St-Jean and Duhamel 2020), identity perspectives (Seibert, Nielsen, and Kraimer 2021; Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022; Zou et al. 2023), self-determination theory (Kautonen et al. 2023) and models of motivation, job satisfaction and job characteristics (Gray and Smith 2020). Some studies acknowledge the influence of the career environment on transitions. However, few studies concentrate on previously employed individuals' career and social capital or their transition pathways to self-employment.

The role of the career environment in transitions remains unexplored. Research has examined the motives and experiences of corporate employees transitioning to self-employment, with some focus on women (Sinisalo and Komulainen 2008) and public sector employees like academics (Zou et al. 2023). Özcan and Reichstein (2009) explored the motives of public sector employees transitioning to entrepreneurship, noting that the bureaucratic nature of the public sector, with limited individual discretion and lack of performance-based incentives, can lead to frustration and drive some toward self-employment. Although a strong identification with workplace peers may deter self-employment (Özcan and Reichstein 2009; Obschonka et al. 2012), studies from the US suggest that public servants like military veterans are more inclined toward self-employment than non-military counterparts (Heinz et al. 2017).

This study focuses on this understudied group of public sector employees, particularly military veterans, exploring how they leverage their career and social capital to navigate pathways toward entrepreneurship. It aims to provide a nuanced understanding of the role of the career environment (structuration) and individual agency in these transitions.

2.1. Holistic career perspectives and entrepreneurial career pathways

This paper explores work-to-self-employment career transitions aligned to contemporary career models like boundaryless and protean careers (Arthur 2014; Guan et al. 2019). These models acknowledge individual agency through self-determined 'career choices' in

Table 1. Overview of recent work-to-self-employment career transition studies (2020–2024).

Authors	Method	Country	Research question	Type of entrepreneurial transition	Theories used	Research Philosophy	Career/social capital	Transition pathway	Focal interest
Gray and Smith 2020	Semi-structured interviews, $n = 8$	UK	Why do professionals with established careers that choose to start a business later in life?	Senior entrepreneurs (50+)	Review literature on motivation, resources, and environmental determinants.	Not specified	No	No	Motivations of late career transitions
St-Jean and Duhamel 2020	GEM 2013 panel data, $n = 36129$ employees	70 countries	Determine whether dissatisfaction with salaried work and low potential for work-life balance can explain entrepreneurial intention.	Entrepreneurial intent	Entrepreneurial event model (EEM) and TPB (theory of planned behavior)	Positivist	No	No	Entrepreneurial intent across innovation-driven and other economies
Seibert, Nielsen, and Kraimer 2021	Quantitative, $n = 226$	N.S.	Develops and tests a model of paid employment transition to entrepreneurship	Entrepreneurial intent	Entrepreneurial identity displacing work events	Positivist	No	No	Displacement event and entrepreneurial intent
Ramnath et al. 2021	Panel data	US	Examine if workers over 50 use self-employment as a 'bridge job' before retirement.	Senior entrepreneurs (50+)	Not applicable	Positivist	No	No	Pathways to retirement via self-employment
Orchia 2021	Panel data	Ghana	Investigate job-to-job transitions	Self-employment	Not applicable	Positivist	No	No	Work-to-self-employment yields higher returns, but if the first job is self-employment, lifetime adverse effects on later earnings.
Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022	Interviews, $n = 28$	Denmark	How a new entrepreneurial identity forms with prior work-related identities during sponsored self-employment after an emotional job loss.	Career dismissal/redundancy to self-employment	Entrepreneurial identity via an adjustment perspective	Grounded theory	No	No	Four types of identity transitions and processes via liminal states
Kautonen et al. 2023	Panel data 2002–2019	UK	How does switching from paid employment to entrepreneurship late career influence self-realization in the short and medium-term	Senior entrepreneurs (50+)	Self-determination theory	Positivist	No	No	Late career transition to self-employment's effect on self-realization

(continued)

Table 1. Continued.

Authors	Method	Country	Research question	Type of entrepreneurial transition		Theories used	Research Philosophy	Career/social capital	Transition pathway	Focal interest
				Academics to entrepreneurs	entrepreneurs					
Zou et al. 2023	Interviews, $n = 24$	China	Can academic entrepreneurs achieve harmonious roles during their career transition?			Role harmony, identity theory, social identity theory	Interpretive	No	No	Inverted relationship between scholarly identification and role harmony with entrepreneurial narratives playing a sense-making role.
Gu et al. 2024	Panel data, $n = 18$ 775 employees	Australia	Explain the relationship between work-to-self-employment and job satisfaction from the perspective of job quality.	Self-employment		Job satisfaction and job characteristics (job autonomy and skill variety)	Positivist	No	No	Job satisfaction and job quality of self-employment
Song 2024	Interviews, $n = 17$	China	Examine why women transition from wage work to self-employed entrepreneurship, the seemingly insecure and unvarying economic sector	Women		Gendered perspective	Interpretive	No	No	Motivations of women transitioning from wage work to self-employment
This study	In-depth interviews, $n = 21$	Australia	How do contextual factors influence career transitions? How do career and social capital influence career transitions? and the career transition pathways of military veteran entrepreneurs	Public sector transition of military veteran entrepreneurs		Integrate career imagination, adjustment and capital perspective	Social constructionism	Yes	Yes	Career transition pathways from public sector work to self-employment through career imagination, career and social capital

shaping career pathways (Haenggli et al. 2021), given the need for such studies (Akkermans et al. 2024). Cohen and Duberley (2021) conceptualisation of career imagination illustrates how careers are shaped through the interplay of structure and individual agency, considering career scripts and individual proactiveness (Andresen et al. 2020; Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024).

A recent review of career transitions highlights the need to integrate interdependent theoretical perspectives to understand individuals' career decisions as decisions and adjustments that influence identity and relationships during transitions (Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). Career mobility pathways are complex and dynamic (Tran, Baruch, and Bui 2021), requiring a process-driven approach (Akkermans et al. 2024). Thus, exploring career transitions necessitates considering individuals' unique career contexts and their related career and social capital (Bourdieu 2018). Concentrating on work-to-self-employment, we integrate career imagination (Cohen and Duberley 2021) and the career competencies perspectives related to career and social capital (DeFillippi and Arthur 1994; Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b) to gain insight into the decisions and adjustments made during entrepreneurial career transitions.

Career imagination refers to how individuals envision their professional lives within their social and temporal settings, influencing what they see as possible and attainable. It provides a lens for understanding career transitions, considering both cognitive and interpretive dimensions beyond traditional career scripts (Cohen and Duberley 2021). Career imagination is shaped by individuals' personal, social, and contextual circumstances, encompassing values, norms, and identities (Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024) and career and social capital (Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b).

Career imagination provides a valuable framework to study career transitions for three reasons. First, it bridges the gap between individual aspirations and societal expectations, integrating structure and agency to show how transitions are both socially constructed and individually navigated. Second, it recognizes individuals' social embeddedness, explaining how some career transitions become accepted within specific groups through the socialization of norms, values, and practices. Third, it provides an in-depth perspective to explore the complexities of career pathways within dynamic career contexts (Cohen and Duberly 2021; Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024). The dimensions of career imagination and social and career capital inform the scope of change and possibilities for work-to-self-employment transitions, forming the foundation of our proposed conceptual framework.

2.2. Factors influencing work to self-employment career transitions

Following Sullivan and Al Ariss (2021) recommendation for embracing a holistic career perspective to better appreciate work-to-self-employment career transitions, we developed a conceptual framework, as shown in Figure 1, to guide the interpretation of career transition experiences, integrating career imagination with career and social capital.

Career imagination includes three main dimensions of perceptions of enablement and constraints, temporality during adjustment, and self and social identity (Cohen and Duberley 2021). It enables an understanding of the structural career context,

individual agency and adjustments during the transition pathway, while career and social capital aids in understanding how individuals leverage their career competencies (DeFillippi and Arthur 1994; Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b), informing the four components of the conceptual model of Figure 1.

2.2.1. Barriers and facilitators of career transitions

Barriers and facilitators of career transitions relate to the first dimension of career imagination, recognizing that these are contextually bound (Cohen and Duberley 2021). In work-to-entrepreneurship transitions, occupational norms and past work experience influence career pathways. The contextual embeddedness shows how social structures interrelate with career decisions, with transitions enabled and constrained by prior experience. Therefore, this dimension aids in interpreting barriers and facilitators of career transitions related to experiential learning and perceptions of enablement and constraint (Cohen and Duberley 2021), as shown in Figure 1. Whether necessity or opportunity-driven, the reasons for starting a business are linked to career context and specific work circumstances (Bañón, Sánchez, and Vivaracho 2012; Gray and Smith 2020). Entrepreneurs choose career paths based on goals, socialization, and opportunities (Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev 2016). Miller and Le Breton Miller's (2017) challenge-based entrepreneurship (CBE) model highlights adaptability as a career resource.

Career transitions present personal challenges, decision-making skills, and anxiety also impact career choices (Gati and Kulcsár 2021). Displacement events in career environments bring challenges and opportunities, prompting individuals to consider shifting from work to entrepreneurship (Seibert, Nielsen, and Kraimer 2021; Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022). Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva (2024) confirmed that their career context impacted theatre actors in Flanders. This study focuses on understanding the work-to-entrepreneurship career transition (Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev 2016, 237), focusing on military veterans, given that so little is known about these transitions.

2.2.2. Career capital and social capital

Career and social capital are linked to the boundaryless career perspective, which emphasizes knowing-why, knowing-how, and knowing-whom as key competencies (DeFillippi and Arthur 1994). Knowing-why pertains to an individual's motivation,

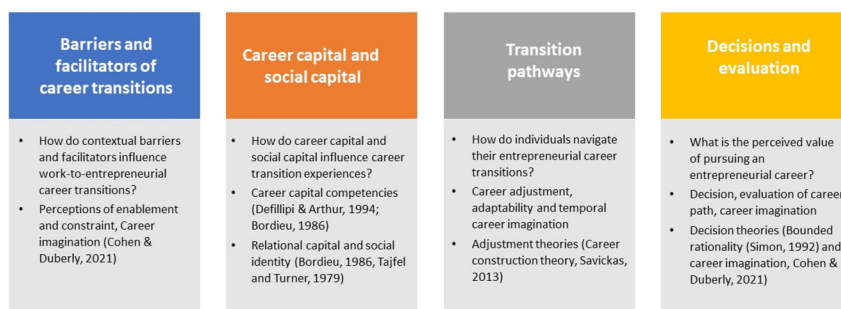


Figure 1. Conceptual framework for work-to-self-employment career transitions.

and identity, emphasizing a coherent sense of self not being reliant on one organization, but on varied job experiences (Eby, Butts, and Lockwood 2003). Knowing-how represents career assets through skills, knowledge, and expertise that are transferable across organizations (DeFillippi and Arthur 1994). Individuals use their unique talents and skills during transitions to shape their aspirations. Knowing-whom refers to social capital, including networks, mentorships, and connections (Zou et al. 2023). An extensive network is valuable for accessing new entrepreneurial opportunities, forming the second component of the Figure 1 framework.

Career capital emphasizes having diverse skills for successful career transitions (Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b). This concept aligns with entrepreneurial bricolage, which involves creating new solutions (and ventures) using existing experiences (Senyard et al. 2014), recognizing experiential learning and the value of transferable skills, experience and networks gained in different industries and situations (Inkson and Arthur 2001). Transferable skills relevant to entrepreneurship include analytical thinking, innovativeness, problem-solving, creativity, and initiative (Koch, Park, and Zahra 2021). Parker (2004) found that as individuals gain work experience, they accumulate human and social capital for perceiving and exploiting market opportunities. Career capital facilitates skill development, like business and management expertise, essential for entrepreneurial success (Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b).

Recent literature on work-to-entrepreneurship transitions has yet to thoroughly examine career capital, though some recognize the important role of education (Otchia 2021; Zou et al. 2023). Kerrick et al. (2014) found that entrepreneurial education positively influences entrepreneurship among military veterans. Conversely, Crecente, Sarabia, and del Val (2021) discovered that mandatory military service does not necessarily increase entrepreneurial propensity. However, veterans develop adaptive capabilities by making decisions in stressful, uncertain situations. Brown, Hooley, and Wond (2020b) highlight that career capital aids in developing effective transition strategies. However, how career capital is utilized when transitioning from work-to-entrepreneurship remains unclear, making it a focus of this study.

Social capital is the value in the social relationships of individuals or groups (Adler and Kwon 2002) and plays a vital role in entrepreneurial careers (Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev 2016). It facilitates career transitions through support from various sources (Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b). These networks provide resources, bridging decision-making gaps for senior entrepreneurs' late-career transitions (Gray and Smith 2020; Kautonen et al. 2023). A study by Avrahami and Lerner (2003) found that 166 Israeli MBA graduates with combat experience possessed unique social capital conducive to enduring bonds. Similarly, studies have shown that veterans maintain strong networks after military service (Kerrick et al. 2014; Crecente, Sarabia, and Teresa del Val 2021). The decision to pursue a career path is also driven by internal and external motivations and social identity perceptions (Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b).

Social capital is tied to social identity theory, which explains that alignment with a particular group influences career decisions and peer relationships (Zou et al. 2023; Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024). Research has long explored the relationship between social identity and career choices, emphasizing the role of group

identification and social cohesion for employees transitioning to entrepreneurship (Obschonka et al. 2012). For military veterans, public service shapes their identity and social relationships, fostering solid organisational commitment and long-term social bonds. Avrahami and Lerner (2003) suggest that military service fosters organisational solid commitment and occupational identification through shared experiences of serving together, altering an individual's life course (Haynie and Shepherd 2011), and cultivating long-term social bonds (McDermott and Jackson 2020). Losing military membership can profoundly impact social identity, prompting veterans to maintain close relationships with fellow veterans (Becker et al. 2022).

Career imagination suggests experiential learning cultivates adaptability for career transitions and outcomes (Savickas and Porfeli 2012; Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). Thus, career capital, social capital, and social identity should be considered in work-to-self-employment transitions. Understanding how individuals leverage their skills, networks, and identities in these transitions can provide valuable insights into the dynamics of entrepreneurial pathways. This study explores these aspects, particularly among military veterans, to contribute to the broader understanding of career transitions into entrepreneurship.

2.2.3. *Transition pathways*

Transition pathways and how individuals adjust to self-employment link to the temporal dimension of career imagination. These transitions reflect path dependency, where past career experiences and adaptations influence future possibilities and actions, creating order and legitimacy (Cohen and Duberly 2021). Temporality extends Super's (1980) career stages, providing a nuanced view of how it interacts with career scripts, guiding decisions and adjustments over time (Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021).

Career imagination also involves an identity dimension, incorporating self-perceptions and socially constructed identities, performed. Individuals' values and ideals provide templates for action, allowing them to envision and pursue specific career paths (Cohen and Duberley 2021). During career transitions, individuals adjust in phases over time (Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). Savickas (2005) career construction theory explains how individuals obtain both objective (e.g. remuneration, status symbols tied to job titles) and subjective (e.g. job satisfaction, flexibility, autonomy) career success through continuous adaptation. These adjustments align with career imagination dimensions, shedding light on the influences that inform the possibilities and shape career transitions (Cohen and Duberley 2021). Figure 1 illustrates varied transition pathways, highlighting adaptation in career journeys.

Career pathways are complex, influenced by individuals' unique, heterogeneous experiences that accumulate to influence choices for meaningful outcomes (Haenggli et al. 2021). Motivations to enter entrepreneurship vary widely (Carsrud and Brännback 2011), encompassing objective achievements and subjective ones like career satisfaction (Koch, Park, and Zahra 2021). Most studies focus on motives (Gray and Smith 2020; Kautonen et al. 2023), measures of career success (Stenard 2019; Otchia 2021; Shu et al. 2023) and the push and pull forces towards entrepreneurship

(Amit and Muller 1995; Tran, Baruch, and Bui 2021), with exploring adaptation pathways. This study aims to gain insight into these varied career journeys.

2.2.4. Decision and evaluation of career transition

Career transitions involve multiple decisions and evaluation events, as shown in Sullivan and Al Ariss (2021) integrated model of transition cycles. Cohen and Duberley (2021) urge scholars to consider the change of scope based on possibilities shaped by structure and agency. Unexpected career events, like technological shifts, economic downturns, wars, or natural disasters, can prompt individuals to reconsider their careers and transition to self-employment (Haynie and Shepherd 2011; Gray and Smith 2020; Burcharth, Smith, and Frederiksen 2022). Therefore, barriers and facilitators of transitions, career and social capital, and transition pathways shape actions and decisions as individuals continuously evaluate their career choices, as depicted in Figure 1.

The literature tends to focus on entrepreneurship as a ‘final destination’ (Burton, Sørensen, and Dobrev 2016, 237) and, as such, examines career outcomes, similar to Savickas’s (2005) objective and subjective success measures. Objective measures are associated with financial compensation, while subjective attainment is linked to job and overall life satisfaction (Koch, Park, and Zahra 2021). St-Jean and Duhamel (2020) found that in innovation-driven economies, job satisfaction and work-life balance in employment decrease the likelihood of starting a business, based on GEM data from 70 countries. Otchia (2021) found that transitioning to self-employment tends to yield higher objective returns in an emerging country like Ghana. Other studies have examined subjective measures in work-to-self-employment transitions (Shu et al. 2023), with McDermott and Jackson (2020) finding that military veteran franchise owners valued autonomy, flexibility and income. Our conceptual model acknowledges individuals’ varied decisions and evaluations during work-to-entrepreneurship transitions.

3. Method

In addressing our research questions and conceptual model, we adopted a social approach to studying career transitions to entrepreneurship (Patton and McMahon 2021; Tran, Baruch, and Bui 2021). We conducted 21 in-depth interviews with military veterans who served in the Australian Defence Force (ADF) for at least five years, transitioned to self-employment, and managed businesses that generated revenue for at least twelve months. These selection criteria ensured that participants had sufficient experience in career transition and entrepreneurship, enabling reflective comparisons of both work contexts.

The study included eighteen self-employed participants and three leaders of organizations supporting military veterans’ transitions. The interviews provided rich insights into lived experiences, a method widely accepted for studying career transitions to entrepreneurship (Boyd, Keith Harrison, and McNerny 2021; Norman, Aiken, and Greer 2024). Support organizations provided additional expertise on military veterans’ transitions and comprehensively informed our coding and interpretation.

Interviews are particularly effective for interpreting entrepreneurs’ lived experiences (Tran, Baruch, and Bui 2021) and well suited to exploring career imagination

(Cohen and Duberley 2021), allowing participants to share their unique life experiences. This approach aids in understanding the interplay between structure and agency (Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024).

3.1. Context of military veteran career transitions

Facilitating veterans' transition to civilian and entrepreneurial careers is crucial in many countries, including the United States (Heinz et al. 2017), the United Kingdom (Edelmann 2018), Australia (Becker et al. 2022), Canada (Rose, VanDenKerkhof, and Schaub 2018), New Zealand (Cardow et al. 2024), South Korea (Oh et al. 2021) and Scandinavian countries (Ahlbäck, Sundevall, and Hjertquist 2024). Sullivan and Al Ariss (2021) underline the need for research on these overlooked, growing groups due to global instability and geopolitical and economic disruptions, with implications for talent management. Similarly, Roundy and Burke-Smalley (2022) highlight the role of interorganizational talent management for entrepreneurship ecosystems, where military veterans represent untapped entrepreneurial capital.

Practically, military veterans make significant sacrifices to serve their countries (Kriner and Shen 2015; Garton 2020). In the US, approximately 200,000 service members transition to civilian life annually (Brown-Barnes et al. 2020). Nearly 500,000 have served in the Australian Defence Force (ADF) (Reid 2023), about 2% of the population in Australia. The number of Australian veterans transitioning to civilian life increased from 5,662 in 2018 to 6,696 in 2022, with continued growth forecasted (Defence and Department of Veteran Affairs 2023). In the UK, around 13,000 leave the armed forces annually (Office of Veterans' Affairs 2022). Globally, governments invest in veterans' well-being through employment programs and support, recognizing their valuable skills (Kumar and Jain 2021; Becker et al. 2022).

Theoretically, military veteran entrepreneurs are an appropriate group, as they represent an extreme case of work-to-self-employment career transitions, given deep occupation attachment. Such cases allow scholars to achieve discovery-related goals and enhance their understanding of career transitions (Haynie and Shepherd 2011; Seawright 2016). Veterans' perceptions of enablement and constraint are tied to their cultural embeddedness in their employment context and the socialization experienced during basic military service (Shue et al. 2024; Oh et al. 2021). The military environment socializes members to conform to norms, rules and behaviours. Veterans' social bonds are strongly tied to their service, forming enduring connections (Edelmann 2018), often strengthened by combat experience (Avrahami and Lerner 2003; Haynie and Shepherd 2011). Scholars note that veterans' occupational identity is enduring, and transitioning to civilian or self-employment requires significant adjustment (Becker et al. 2022; Kaspersen 2024). These transitions require redefining professional and social identity to align with their new career path (Boyd, Keith Harrison, and McInerney 2021), thus making veteran entrepreneurs an appropriate group to study.

3.2. Data collection

After gaining ethics approval from the Australian Defence Force Ethics Committee (Protocol number DDVA 199-20), the University of New South Wales (HC200122),

and the University of the Sunshine Coast (A201368), 75 potential businesses were identified through the Australian Veteran Owned Business network and invited participate. This was supplemented by purposive snowball sampling, which is suitable for accessing this ‘hidden’ group (Marshall and Rossman 2014). This approach allowed for interviewing participants from diverse backgrounds and transition experiences. Interviews lasted forty minutes to 1.5 h, using a semi-structured interview protocol. Most interviews were conducted *via* videoconferencing, with a few in-person. Interviews were tailored to each participant’s experiences, as interviews aimed to gather rich narratives about their venture journey and the support they used during their career transition. The protocol was designed to gain insight into participants’ varied lived experiences, aligned to the conceptual framework, with topic areas outlined in Table 2.

While the interview protocol focused on critical areas of interest, interviewers were flexible, encouraging participants to share their views freely, capture unforeseen responses, and embrace social constructionism (Marshall and Rossman 2014). Interviews were audio recorded, transcribed, and de-identified using participant numbers.

3.3. Data analysis

A deductive and inductive thematic analysis (Fereday and Muir-Cochrane 2006) was conducted to extend theory and explore the diversity of veteran entrepreneurs’ career transitions. Thematic analysis is a flexible method for identifying, analyzing, and reporting meaningful patterns when coding qualitative data (Braun and Clarke 2022). Our analysis was guided by the conceptual framework in Figure 1 and the research questions, providing a theory-based template to code data segments aligned with a deductive approach (Crabtree and Miller 1999).

New codes and themes emerged that did not fit the predefined categories, allowing for inductive analysis and reflecting a close grounding to the data (Braun and Clarke

Table 2. Career transition interview guide.

Conceptual framework	Interview Questions
Career transition context	Tell me more about your background (Prompt for gender, education, military service, Australian Defence Force background)
Evaluation of career transition to self-employment	Tell me more about your business (Prompt for industry, number of employees, development) What are some of the benefits and outcomes of running your own business?
Transition pathway and process	Tell me about your transition from military service (Prompts: when, how long, what was the process) At any point in the transition process, was entering your venture, as suggested by others, a possibility for you?
Reflection and adjustment	When did you develop this business idea, and how did you start?
Career capital	What skills and knowledge did you need to start your own business? Did the things you learnt whilst in Defense assist you? Were there skills or knowledge you needed to develop to enable you to start your venture, and if so, how did you get these?
Barriers and facilitators of career transition	What was most challenging about moving from the Defense Force into your business? (Prompts: starting the business, friends, family, and former colleagues)
Social capital	What helped you to transition into starting your own business? (Prompts: delve into business, the market, skill set, mentors, an organization or you/your family)

2022). A rigorous four-step coding process (Spiggle 1994) included precoding preparation (familiarizing with the data), first-order eclectic coding, categorization, and themes identified. The research team reviewed and discussed the codes to ensure emergent categories and themes accurately reflected the data. Emergent themes underwent empirical refutation to promote epistemic warrants, capturing veteran entrepreneurs' transition and entrepreneurial experiences. Representative quotes are included in the themes to provide close grounding to the data.

3.3.1. Participant profile

The veteran entrepreneurs in this study transitioned from active military service to self-employment, ranging in age from 29 to 60 years. Eighty-one per cent were male, and the other participants were female. Most started businesses focused on service delivery in specialized areas, often drawing on technical or project management skills from their military service. Eighty-six per cent of the businesses concentrate on training, consulting, and communication-related services, with only three in trades, technical or manufacturing sectors. Table 3 provides an overview of the participant profiles, aggregating data on their backgrounds, service, education levels, and different types of self-employment without identifying participants, following ethical guidelines. Given our research design and focus on extending theory, the participant profile aligns with analytical generalizability (Yin 2018) rather than seeking to be representative of all military veterans' transition to self-employment.

4. Findings

The data analysis revealed four themes offerings insights into the research questions, as shown in Table 4. The first theme addresses the barriers and challenges

Table 3. Participant profile.

Demographics	Participants	21
Age	Range	29-60
	Average	42 years
Gender	Male	17
	Female	4
Highest level of education	Secondary school	5
	Post-secondary (certificate, diploma, trade)	8
	UG (Bachelor and Hons)	2
	PG (including 1 PhD)	6
Military background		
Service	Army	16
	Navy	4
	Air Force	1
Rank on discharge	Senior Officers (O5 and Above)	0
	Junior Officers (O1 to O4)	8
	Warrant Officer and Senior NCOs (E6 to E10)	1
	Junior NCOs and below E1 to E5	12
Business		
Industry	Manufacturing and technical	3
	Services	18
Relatedness to a military role	Related	15
	Unrelated	6
Career transition support organizations	Contextual interviews for interpretation and expertise in facilitating career transitions	3

Table 4. Main themes.

Main Themes	Sub-theme	Brief overview
Theme one: Transitioning challenges and motivation	Transition barriers and challenges	Impersonal, broken, and complex process. Lack of guidance, support, and information. Financial decisions and adjustments, e.g. debt and reorganizing personal finances. Articulating military-acquired skills in the private sector and industry jargon. Lack of structure and benchmarks.
	Motivation facilitating opportunity-driven entries (45%)	Use existing skills and ideas to create opportunities.
	Motivation facilitating market-driven entry (30%)	Become aware of feasible marketable solutions/ innovations while in service and pursue them when transitioned.
	Motivation facilitating formalizing a side hustle (25%)	Existing hobbies or side activities are pursued full-time and built into a feasible business.
Theme two: Career capital	In-service skills	Technical, operational, procedural and management skills acquired in service
	Post-transition	Identified and acquired specific finance, accounting, marketing, social media and personal branding skills.
Theme three: Social Capital	Network and support	Other military veterans, mentors, military support organizations, industry-related networks, business and veteran-owned business networks.
Theme four: The Perceived Value of an Entrepreneurial Pathway	Improved wellbeing	Increased self-esteem and sense of accomplishment
	Autonomy and flexibility	Freedom, control, and flexibility for improved wellbeing
	Satisfaction	Happiness, passion, enjoyment

participants encountered during their transition to entrepreneurship, including financial constraints, resource scarcity, and acquiring new skills and knowledge. Alongside these challenges, facilitators and motivations emerged such as the desire for autonomy, flexibility, and control over their careers, personal growth and fulfilment.

The second theme centers on career capital, encompassing the skills, experiences, and knowledge participants leveraged to advance their careers. We found participants' career capital was critical in their transition decision. They drew from their previous work experience and skills to develop new products and services, build networks, and establish their businesses.

The third theme explores participants' social capital, which includes the networks, relationships, and social resources individuals access to achieve their goals. Social capital played a vital role in their transition. Participants relied on their social networks, including family, friends, mentors, and business partners, for financial support, acquiring new knowledge, and establishing businesses.

The final theme examines the perceived value of transitioning to entrepreneurship. Participants perceived entrepreneurship as a means to achieve personal and professional fulfilment, create value for others, and contribute to society. They viewed it as an opportunity to pursue their passions, express their creativity, and positively impact their communities.

4.1. Theme one: transitioning challenges and motivations

Participants experienced various barriers and challenges during the transition. One participant expressed the feeling of *"having to know everything"* (P1). Sixty per cent of

the participants acknowledged that they were too proud to admit the challenges they faced, contributing to feelings of isolation and personal loss, causing them to disconnect from their friends and colleagues. They also avoided being perceived as excelling faster than their peers to maintain a sense of *mateship*. This theme is related to their embeddedness and how they 'lift' themselves from these feelings and situations. For instance, 72% built networks with similar individuals and developed effective routines and frameworks, reflecting proactiveness and adaptability. Others pursued formal education by enrolling in training programs or degrees to gain the required credentials.

Motives that facilitated starting a new business were categorized as opportunity identification, addressing a market gap, or formalizing a side hustle. Many used their prior training and skills acquired during their military service to start new businesses. For instance, one participant said, *"I see the ability for me to coalesce all the learning that I do have from the ADF and apply it to this new world, from a technical standpoint and the underlying processes."* During their military service or transition, 30% identified a feasible market for an idea or solution to improve processes, which they planned to pursue post-military service. As one participant noted, *"It was just the genesis of all the work within, I guess, the last four years of my service career. I saw opportunities and these things starting to come up, bubble up within the Defense arena, technologies like virtual reality and mixed reality solutions, as it allows a degree of creativity you are not afforded within the ADF."* The remaining 25% of participants started a side hustle that grew into a full-time business. One explained, *"That is where it started as a side hustle while I was doing the study."* Participants experienced the transition process as a defining moment, enabling them to pursue ideas they have considered for some time, *"So I wanted to expand my mind further and challenge myself and, yeah, take a leap. I had to do it at some point."* (P15).

4.2. Theme two: career capital

The career capital theme relates to participants' skills and experiences accumulated during and after transitioning, distinguished as in-service and post-transition skills.

4.2.1. Sub-theme 2.1 in-service skills

Participants found it easier to adjust to civilian life by leveraging their technical skills, as these were universally understood. For instance, one veteran explained, *"I was able to adapt and apply my technical skills."* Management skills gained during service were also crucial for starting a venture. Another veteran explained, *"As a commander, I learned the management style of running things. This included creating documents, following work processes, setting KPIs, and other similar tasks. (P10)."* Analytical skills, planning, decision-making, a methodological mindset, and practical communication skills were also applicable. For example, one veteran said, *"The military has become quite good at adapting in different ways. It assists with business planning by developing a course of action that outlines all the potential risks and issues associated with a particular path. This is crucial as a skill set."* In-service skills enabled participants to set up new ventures and cultivate networks, as these skills are transferable. *"I've tried to*

... (help others realize) ... (e.g.,) an ex-Regimental Sergeant Major coming in now to be a general manager. And he's like, I don't know business. (He answers) ... You've been running with all the logistics management and stuff behind us, and you've done everything. Until you show them that's how business works, they're like (they think) army is bigger; you're dealing with its biggest transition, you're dealing with a multi-billion-dollar enterprise" (P18). These skills can also be leveraged in ambiguous entrepreneurial environments, for example: "... high-risk, high-stress environments ... with so many moving parts and different relationships over multiple businesses to come into this" (P18).

Human resource and team management were critical organizational skills developed during service. Veterans' personal knowledge, teamwork, and operational skills helped them organize their ventures and execute projects. Values like attention to detail, integrity, respect, and professionalism facilitated the transition to entrepreneurship. As one veteran explained: "*The Australian Defence Force trains you very well, directly and indirectly, you build up good corporate knowledge. You can manage people and technology. Sometimes, that is not easy. Managing people and managing technology is not necessarily the same thing. The ADF does that quite well in most cases because the skills, technology, and individuals make it all work*" (P9).

4.2.2. Sub-theme 2.2 post-transition skills

During their transition to entrepreneurship, many participants realized they needed more specific skills and knowledge to navigate the demands of starting a new business. While they worked on upskilling and reskilling, one notable challenge was understanding financial management and accounting.

Some participants, especially those in service and client-focused firms, mentioned struggling with marketing, promotion, and sales, especially on social media, "... at some point, you didn't know ... how to create a business, how to instil insurances, how to bring recruits in ... things like social media, I never got to use social media in the military, it was prohibited, and heavily restricted. And now... I could use it any way I wanted, but I had no idea how it worked, its benefits, and its pros and cons. So, that was a bit of a steep learning curve for me. I was fortunate enough not to make too many stupid mistakes. Knowing a bit more about the power of social media, I think, would have been nice, but it's not a case of it was to any detriment not knowing that, at the time I needed to use it, I learned it quickly. I asked key questions ... people were happy to help, just random strangers or people I knew doing similar small business startups. And they're more than willing to share their knowledge and insights." (P7).

Developing personal and business branding was another substantial challenge, involving a personal and social identity transition that was complex and unexpected. This shift is described in the identity literature as a state of flux, reflection, and metamorphosis into entrepreneurship (Stern 2017). One of the participants (P11) experienced a transition, which caused them to question their identity, asking, "Who am I now, and how do I contribute?" For them, it was necessary to feel valued and to be able to contribute to their personal development.

4.3. Theme three: social capital

As veterans transitioned out of service, they found peers, who were also veterans, to be a great source of motivation and encouragement. One participant (P5) shared: *"Support structure, I did not feel I needed one; the army was always there whenever I needed an idea or help. I had people who were former colleagues in the army who had left the army previously. I was able to leverage some of their experiences and knowledge, asking questions and getting their sort of support. My key support structure was mates who had been in the army and had left previously."* These peers helped expand their professional networks and encouraged them to seek mentorship. *"Mentoring, mentoring, that would probably be the biggest one having a mentor, or at least having a lot of them shy away from it. However, having a group session probably once a quarter sitting down and just winging or brainstorming about the transition... and how people adapt to it"* (P4).

Participants who leveraged their active networks before and during their service could easily reconnect with their peers during and after their transition. These networks included industry-related connections and broader professional networks (e.g. local business chambers and veteran-owned business networks). *"Professional societies helped ... [to create] ... the network, the people I knew. Moreover, it allowed me to make some very good friends in the industry outside of Australia, as well as inside of Australia, and that became quite useful"* (P9).

Awareness of military support organizations and access to social capital and support played a crucial role in participants' transitions. They sought support and information from these organizations and engaged in networks that helped them. For instance, *"The Prince's Trust was probably a good pathway for me to help work things out. I guess that is something that's already there that's useful. I don't think there's anything else on offer that helps people set up a business. Even just the network of other military people going through the same thing I met. It's just nice to know that there's a network out there"* (P21).

4.4. Theme four: the perceived value of an entrepreneurial pathway

Following an entrepreneurial pathway offers positive outcomes after transition, such as improved well-being, autonomy, personal satisfaction, and accomplishment.

4.4.1. Sub-theme 4.1 improved wellbeing

Veterans facing challenges with PTSD and other mental and physical health issues identified the need to adapt mentally to life after service. However, creating a new venture accompanied by a sense of accomplishment improved self-esteem and overall well-being. One veteran shared, *"I saw myself in uniform, as someone with a distinguished position in society, as an army officer. You know, the way we present ourselves to being someone else again. However, I didn't hold on to that for too long... Success helps you create a new identity for yourself and helps you appreciate your former life without being defined by it. It is part of my life and not who I am anymore"* (P12).

4.4.2. Sub-theme 4.2 autonomy and flexibility

Self-employment allowed participants to prioritize their well-being, pursue passions, and customize their work environment. They experienced autonomy and could set their schedules based on personal needs and preferences. This independence and sense of control motivated them to embrace the risks and uncertainties of entrepreneurship. Despite setbacks, they believed that as long as they continued moving forward, the rewards would outweigh the risks in the long run. As one participant stated, *"I'm a realist in that regard. However, as long as I keep stepping forward, that is the endgame for five years from now. It is not next week. And I have got the eyes on the prize."* (P14)

4.2.3. Sub-theme 4.3 satisfaction

Participants reported that pursuing their passions and controlling their work schedule gave them a sense of pride and satisfaction. One participant stated, *"So, it is much joy. And I get paid for it."* (P9). However, they were also mindful of the potential for burnout and the importance of managing this well. One participant shared: *"It presented a challenge because I enjoy being challenged. I could throw myself into it and enjoy the long hours and days again. However, I have renewed motivation to do it because I'm doing something more focused on what I want to do rather than what the army is telling me to do."* (P7). For some, the perceived value of an entrepreneurial career is derived from the satisfaction and joy of their venture. As one stated, *"To be honest, it is a day-by-day, week-by-week basis. I'm keen to grow, but five years from now, if we're still in this, and we're still enjoying it, and we're still taking care of people, then I would consider that successful"* (P7). Satisfaction was also linked to how their work made them feel: *"If you love what you are doing. Moreover, you do it all the time, you know. Moreover, you do it during your rest or down periods. It's because you love doing it... I don't dread going to work in the mornings... The days are too short because they're filled; I'm not watching the clock saying it's nearly time to go home. I've never done that."* (P20).

5. Discussion

This qualitative research contributes to the entrepreneurship and career literature by focusing on work-to-entrepreneurship transitions. By integrating career imagination and career and social capital, we offer a holistic view of career transitions (Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021), synthesizing structuralist and agentic perspectives. The experiences of military veterans transitioning to entrepreneurship enrich our understanding of how organizational embeddedness shapes career imagination, informing transition enablement and constraints. Leveraging career capital and social capital shapes transition pathways as individuals adjust through multiple decisions and reflections, assessing the value of their new career, as shown in Figure 2's integrative framework of career pathways from work to self-employment.

Our findings align with career imagination's key tenant: how individuals perceive facilitators and barriers defines and delimits what they view as possible and legitimate during transitions. Military veterans leveraged their skills, learned from others and

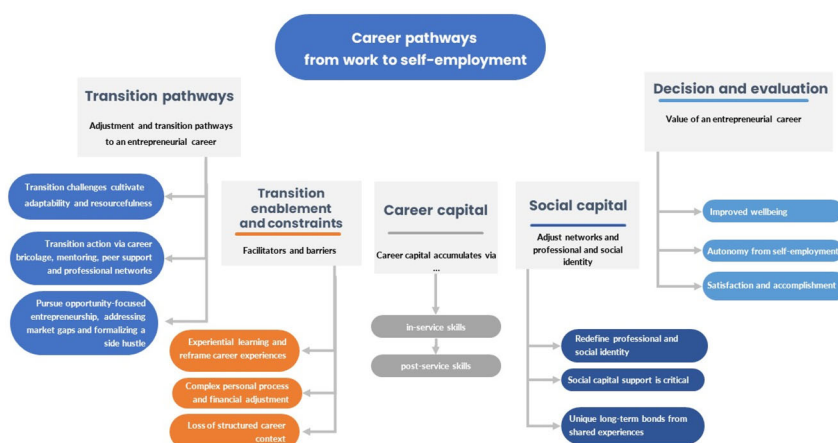


Figure 2. Integrative framework of work to self-employment career pathways.

adapted through trial and error to pursue entrepreneurial opportunities and address market gaps by leveraging their skills, learning from others, and using trial-and-error learning. However, their career context and circumstances also created constraints, requiring financial adjustments, as they gave up the social and organisational support embedded in their career context. Shue et al. (2021) confirm that losing a structured career context during career transitions is common. This theme aligns with findings of military veterans transitioning to civilian careers (Becker et al. 2022) and Flemish actors framing and reframing career scripts during transitions (Forrier, De Cuyper, and Delva 2024) as they adjust and redefine their occupational narratives. Entrepreneurial framing and reframing in narratives (Snihur et al. 2022) and effectual action (de Villiers Scheepers et al. 2024) is prevalent in the entrepreneurship literature, as it is a catalyst for action, facilitating career transition pathways.

Our findings demonstrate how career imagination relates to structural employment conditions, specifically perceptions of enablement and constraint. These conditions, combined with individuals' reflexive agency, can spur career changes. Despite challenges (Miller and Le Breton-Miller 2017), individuals draw on their career and social capital to reimagine their career paths and transition to self-employment.

Career and social capital shape career transition actions, facilitating agentic behaviour. Career capital accumulates through developing in-service and post-transition skills, which veterans leverage using career *bricolage* as they transition to entrepreneurship. Our findings confirm that experiential, in-service learning benefits career mobility, similar to Brown, Hooley, and Wond (2020b), as it cultivates personal resources to develop new ventures. These findings extend bricolage (Senyard et al. 2014) to career transitions, as our findings show how veterans adapted and recombined their intangible resources and skills. In-service skills, the ability to perform under extreme pressure and learning from professional networks post-transition resulted in transferable skills for entrepreneurial practice. Our findings highlight the importance of bricolage and leveraging the unique career capital during work-to-self-employment transitions.

Social capital plays a critical role in transitions as individuals gradually adjust their networks, weak ties, and professional and social identities. Military veteran

entrepreneurs, like traditional entrepreneurs, rely heavily on social capital to secure resources, support, and knowledge needed for their businesses. Our findings indicate that strong ties from familial and occupational relationships, developed through shared experiences, play a vital role in transitions to entrepreneurship. In a structured career context, where individuals are deeply embedded, their unique long-term bonds from shared experiences shape enduring social capital, as Avrahami and Lerner (2003) confirm. These bonds are valuable for new ventures, enduring beyond their military service, consistent with work by Kerrick et al. (2014) and Crecente, Sarabia, and Teresa del Val (2021). Post-transition, some veteran entrepreneurs use weak ties from professional networks to exchange knowledge and find support. As their weak ties extend beyond the occupational context, redefining their professional and social identities becomes relevant, especially in areas like social media marketing.

Our findings extend the entrepreneurship career transition literature by expounding three transition pathways in work-to-self-employment transitions. As Sullivan and Al Ariss (2021) emphasize, career transitions involve multiple adjustments, decisions, and actions, as shown in Figure 2. Viewing transition pathways as a series of emergent career imagination adjustments highlights the contingency and temporality of actions. First, our findings show that transition challenges cultivate adaptability and resourcefulness as individuals leverage adversities as strengths and develop competencies such as resourcefulness when embracing an entrepreneurial pathway (Fisher 2024). Second, individuals embrace transition actions by drawing on career bricolage, professional networks, peer support and mentoring. Mentoring and peer support from experienced veteran entrepreneurs facilitated personal and professional growth, supporting the transition. Mentoring is effective for novice entrepreneurs (St-Jean, Radu-Lefebvre, and Mathieu 2018), military veterans (Rose, VanDenKerkhof, and Schaub 2018) and senior entrepreneurs (Maritz, Eager, and de Klerk 2021). Third, individuals pursue varied forms of entrepreneurship, including opportunity-focused entrepreneurship, addressing market gaps and formalizing a side hustle. These findings point to emerging work examining dual careers (Winand, Bell, and Zeimers 2023; Steinbrink and Ströhle 2024) and hybrid entrepreneurship (Pollack et al. 2019) as pathways to pursuing entrepreneurial careers as fruitful areas for future research. This suggests that career planning and preparation are vital when transitioning to entrepreneurship, underscoring employers' need to support self-employment transitions (Gati and Kulcsar 2021).

The scope of change experienced in the career transition is characterized by individuals' decisions and evaluations of an entrepreneurial career's value, as shown in Figure 2. Career imagination and career and social capital inform the possibilities and trajectories of what is possible, with entrepreneurial careers offering material rewards and intangible benefits (Cohen and Duberley 2021). The scope of change is multi-dimensional, impacting career enactment. Our findings show that the perceived value of pursuing an entrepreneurial career was prominently for intangible benefits of improved well-being, autonomy and self-employment, satisfaction, and accomplishment. Koch, Park, and Zahra (2021) describe these as subjective achievements, while McDermott and Jackson (2020) found veteran franchise owners highly prized autonomy and flexibility. In contrast, material outcomes like financial resources and wealth

motives were not accentuated. Studies examining senior entrepreneurs' late career transitions found that self-employment resulted in a more significant decrease in income compared to mid-career transitions (Ramnath, Shoven, and Slavov 2021). While entrepreneurial failure is a reality many entrepreneurs experience (Byrne 2021), this was not raised by the entrepreneurs of this study. As our research is exploratory, we acknowledge that the decision and evaluation phase is framed positively. Future research could expand and refine the framework to include negative evaluations, allowing for a more nuanced understanding of work-to-self-employment career transitions.

6. Contribution and future research

This paper contributes theoretically to the entrepreneurship and career transition literature and holds managerial implications for employers and individuals considering transitioning to an entrepreneurial career. Theoretically, the integrative model of work-to-self-employment career pathways enriches prior conceptions of this transition in three ways. First, integrating career imagination and career and social capital from the boundaryless career perspective (DeFillippi and Arthur 1994; Brown, Hooley, and Wond 2020b; Cohen and Duberley 2021) synthesizes structural and agency perspectives. This shows how career transitions are shaped by occupational contexts yet enacted by individuals embedded within these contexts. Our framework explains how occupational contexts shape career transition aspirations, highlighting both enabling and constraining perceptions. Second, we emphasize the relevance of leveraging career and social capital to overcome perceived challenges and turn possibilities into legitimate realities. Through continuous adjustment and experiential learning, both skills developed during employment and post-transition skills and competencies shape venture development and professional identity adaptation. As professional networks grow to include more entrepreneurial weak ties, individuals redefine themselves, while some extend their strong ties from prior occupational networks. Finally, the integrative model points to three career transition pathways, reflecting the dynamism of career contexts and the complexities of career pathways. While our model only depicts three pathways, future research can extend this exploratory work, as individuals may imagine and enact their career transitions in diverse ways.

This exploratory study also holds managerial implications for employers, individuals considering work-to-self-employment transitions and interorganizational talent management in entrepreneurship ecosystems. For employers and organizations supporting career transitions, interventions can be improved by enabling employees to reimagine how their career capital could address a market gap, develop 'side hustles', or pursue entrepreneurial opportunities. Involving mentors with prior business and entrepreneurial experience can support career transitions to self-employment. Our findings highlight the importance of preparing, continuous adjustment and leveraging career and social capital. Like Gati and Kulscar (2021), we recommend preparing for a career transition by imagining entrepreneurial potentials and using effectual actions and lean startup principles to develop new ventures (Mansoori and Lack  us 2020).

Finally, for orchestrators of entrepreneurship ecosystems, our findings have implications for talent management through interorganizational practices. Ecosystem coordinators can support career transitions through engagement activities and peer support to attract talent within specific geographic regions (Roundy and Burke-Smalley 2022; Courchesne et al. 2024).

This exploratory study has its limitations, given our methodological approach. While we explored work-to-self-employment career transitions, acknowledging temporality, our reliance on cross-sectional data means that different insights could have emerged if participants were interviewed multiple times during their transition journey. However, given the difficulty of accessing this group, the approach was appropriate to address the research questions. Future research would benefit from longitudinal studies using a process perspective, identifying critical incidents that shape their career pathways and providing insight into how individuals navigate facilitators and challenges.

The occupational context we examined limited our analysis to military veterans' embeddedness, enabling us to provide insight into an extreme context of occupational embeddedness and identification. However, a different occupational and social context may differently influence career imagination, career capital, and social capital. Future research could examine alternative career contexts in the creative industries or compare mid-career with late-career transitions to entrepreneurship, providing more insight into the experiences and career capital at different career stages.

By exploring career transitions from a social constructivist perspective, our findings have analytical generalizability (Yin 2018) but not statistical generalizability. Future research should consider more accessible participant groups and use mixed-method or positivist research designs to examine specific components of the integrative model and their relationships.

In conclusion, the integrative model for work-to-entrepreneurship career transitions offers theoretical contributions for entrepreneurship and career researchers. By synthesizing career imagination, career and social capital perspectives, it highlights how occupational contexts and individual agency shape perceptions of enablement and constraint, identifying alternative career transition pathways and how individuals evaluate the scope of change. Practically, the findings have managerial implications for employers, employed individuals considering self-employment, and orchestrators of entrepreneurial ecosystems. Employers can support employees' career transitions through interventions that enable them to reimagine and leverage their career capital. Individuals can prepare for transitions through effectual actions and networking with experienced entrepreneurs, while orchestrators of entrepreneurship ecosystems and networks can develop entrepreneurial talent by providing supportive networks and resources. Given the study's exploratory nature, several future research opportunities are identified to examine the dynamic nature of career transitions and explore diverse occupational contexts to understand how career imagination, career capital and social capital vary across different career stages and environments.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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